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Restoration and Family

Tree Tag #914

Building upon my reflection from the second part of our “tree reflections,” my most recent visit to my tree left me pondering how we can reverse the damage done to the tree, or at least begin to improve its health. Originally, my best thought was centered around re-establishing the worship of trees (and hopefully this tree specifically) in the students and staff of Baylor’s campus. Thinking back to “Dream of the Rood” from the semester’s beginning, it used to be quite common for people/communities to worship trees...but that died when the Romans took over and changed the previous Anglo-Saxon religion/culture (where they worshipped many things which were not Christ...like trees!). However, trying to get busy student to try and care about trees in their limited free time is not likely to produce any meaningful results. However, I spontaneously made a connection when reading “Underland” by Robert MacFarlane two days ago, right before our class. I realized there was another opportunity/method that was a lot more promising as it was measurable and didn’t require the difficulties involved in instilling habits/desires in humans directly. Instead of trying to get the Baylor community to care, maybe we could use the family of trees which surround it and begin restoring its health at its source (which remains unseen and underground), as MacFarlane’s dying friend explained: “...when one of their number was sickening or under stress, they could share nutrients by means of an underground system that conjoined their roots beneath the soil, thereby sometimes nursing the sick tree back to health” (MacFarlane, 1). I think this quote from MacFarlane’s work may hold the secret in caring for my dying tree.

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For my creative response, I will be creating an informative and persuasive video. This video will inform my viewers on (at least) 3 main things: what is the “wood wide web” which MacFarlane discusses, why we should care about it, and the underlying process of how it works. Ideally, my video will instill inspiration within individuals to take action towards “helping” the “wood wide web,” and more specifically, trees in which we obviously observe a decline in health. I will compare the anatomy of trees to that of the human body to emphasize just how similar we are. Additionally, just like MacFarlane did in “Understory,” I will also touch on how the language of mammals and plants are interweaved. Next, I will give a visual demonstration on how this “wood wide web” works, because people rarely care about things which they fail to understand or sympathize with. Lastly, I will visualize just how dependent our health (as humans) is on these underground plant communities. To conclude the video, I’ll end with by emphasizing my closing remark: Restore our surrounding trees by incorporating it as a part of our family, as well as administering care for the other members of the family in which it belongs to (the other trees, fungi, etc).

Bibliography

MacFarlane, Robert. “Understorey.”